

A Better Boyes Park: Safety, Enhancement and Amenities

Enhancing Amenities Team 3: Tiana Kingi, Caitlin Bird, Min Soe Htut and Patrick Day

Te Whare Wananga o Waikato – University of Waikato

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Executive Summary

This project focuses on the proposed redevelopment of Boyes Park, a public recreational space located in Hamilton City, New Zealand. The work completed involved a comprehensive project management plan aimed at enhancing the park's amenities to better serve the diverse needs of the community. Our objective was to ensure that Boyes Park becomes a safer, more accessible, and inclusive space for individuals of all ages and abilities. The project was initiated in response to community concerns and local government priorities regarding public safety, limited accessibility features, outdated facilities, and a lack of inclusive recreational opportunities. Parks play a vital role in supporting physical, social, and mental well-being, and it is essential that they are designed to meet the needs of all users. Existing research on inclusive designs and the educational backgrounds of our diverse team formed the foundational knowledge for our planning process.

Our project team is composed of four dedicated students with backgrounds in sociology, psychology, Forensics, computer science and digital business, bringing a multidisciplinary approach to this initiative. Each member contributed to different aspects of the project, including research, safety planning, and design proposal development.

In developing this project proposal, we drew on key principles of project management to guide our planning and design considerations, such as understanding stakeholder needs, identifying potential risks, and proposing realistic improvements with a focus on amenities and community-focused redevelopment. We also incorporated frameworks related to universal design and Crime Prevention Through Environmental Design (CPTED) to guide decisions around infrastructure and layout.

Through this report, we present the work we have undertaken to support the revitalisation of Boyes Park into a vibrant, inclusive, and future-ready community space.

Acknowledgements

First, we would like to sincerely thank Ross Ashby from Hamilton City Council for his valuable insights and guidance, which helped shape the direction of our project. His local knowledge and expertise were instrumental in deepening our understanding of Boyes Park and the broader goals of the West Town Belt redevelopment.

We are also grateful to Hamilton City Council for including us in such a meaningful and impactful project for our city. The opportunity to contribute to the future of a significant

community space has been both rewarding and educational.

We also extend our appreciation to our lecturers at the University of Waikato for their ongoing support throughout this project. In particular, we would like to thank Gail Hutcheson, our lecturer for this paper, for her guidance, encouragement, and constructive feedback, which were essential to our learning and the successful completion of this project.

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1. Introduction

This report provides an overview of the Boyes Park redevelopment project, which aimed to enhance the park's functionality, accessibility, and inclusivity in alignment with community needs and Hamilton City Council's broader sustainability and urban planning goals. Located within the historic West Town Belt (a network of interconnected green spaces central to Hamilton's identity), Boyes Park plays an important role in offering recreational, environmental, and cultural value to the local community. However, issues such as limited accessibility, outdated amenities, and underutilisation have highlighted the need for thoughtful redevelopment.

The project was driven by a recognition of these challenges, as well as an understanding of the park's potential to contribute more significantly to community wellbeing, active transport, and social engagement. Our redevelopment proposal focused on improving core infrastructure, including walking and cycling tracks, seating, lighting, rubbish bins, accessible restrooms, and inclusive features such as splash pads and wheelchair-accessible car parking. Additionally, it included plans to refurbish the historic Centennial Fountain, preserving its cultural and historical significance while enhancing its functionality.

This initiative aligns with the West Town Belt Masterplan and Hamilton City Council's sustainability goals, which prioritise accessible, safe, and vibrant public spaces. Our team brought together a range of academic and practical strengths to meet the goals of this project. Our interdisciplinary team worked collaboratively to ensure a well-rounded and effective project. Tiana Kingi (Psychology & Sociology) and Min Soe Htut (Computer Science) led the planning, spatial analysis, and site mapping to inform the layout and prioritisation of features. Caitlin Bird (Psychology & Forensic Psychology) contributed her expertise in public safety and wellbeing to help ensure the design promoted a secure and welcoming environment. Patrick Day (Digital Business) played a key role in analysing the effectiveness of our research methods and proposed amenities. As a team, we collectively reviewed, refined, and finalised all aspects of the proposal to create a cohesive and impactful redevelopment plan.

Together, our interdisciplinary approach ensured that the project was grounded in both community wellbeing and evidence-based planning. The following sections of this report detail the background research, planning process, proposed improvements, and critical reflections on our collaborative efforts to enhance Boyes Park.

2. Context

Hamilton City Council (HCC) is a medium-sized local government organisation that serves the city of Hamilton (Kirikiriroa), one of Aotearoa New Zealand's fastest-growing urban centres. As a territorial authority, HCC is responsible for delivering essential public services, maintaining infrastructure, and leading sustainable urban development across the region. This includes

management of transport systems, water and waste services, housing and zoning regulations, and more than 200 parks and recreational spaces (Hamilton City Council, 2021a).

HCC operates under a public service model, meaning its primary purpose is to meet the needs of residents, businesses, and visitors rather than generate profit. Its mission is grounded in community wellbeing, with a vision to create a vibrant, accessible, and liveable city. This is reflected in the Council's strategic documents such as the *2021-31 Long-Term Plan* and the *West Town Belt Masterplan*, which emphasise green development, social inclusion, and enhanced public amenities as core pillars of Hamilton's future (Hamilton City Council, 2021b).

The "clientele" of HCC includes the city's 180,000+ residents, with particular attention to families, youth, older adults, disabled persons, and tangata whenua. Hamilton's diverse and rapidly growing population places increasing pressure on public infrastructure, particularly parks and recreational spaces, which are vital for physical health, social connection, and environmental sustainability (Ministry of Housing and Urban Development, 2021). Spaces like Boyes Park must therefore be designed and maintained to meet varied and evolving community needs.

While HCC does not compete in a traditional business sense, it does face competition from private recreational facilities (e.g., gyms, private reserves, commercial events) and from expanding suburban developments that offer newer amenities. In this context, the redevelopment of public parks plays a key role in ensuring that central city spaces remain attractive, functional, and equitable for all residents.

Boyes Park, located within the historically and ecologically significant West Town Belt, was selected for redevelopment due to its outdated infrastructure, limited accessibility, and underutilisation. The site's current state does not reflect its potential as a vibrant urban green space. Redeveloping the park aligns with both HCC's long-term strategic goals and the growing community demand for inclusive, safe, and well-equipped outdoor environments (Department of Internal Affairs, 2020).

This project responds directly to those needs by improving core infrastructure, such as pathways, restrooms, lighting, and inclusive features, while also restoring historical landmarks like the Centennial Fountain. In doing so, it enhances the park's cultural, recreational, and environmental value, ensuring it can better serve Hamilton's diverse and growing population into the future.

3. Methods and Procedures

We began our study by carrying out multiple in-person site visits to Boyes Park to gain an understanding of current functionality and areas in need of improvement. During these visits, we

photographed and documented every major feature from the lack of play structures and seating clusters to the meandering pathways paying close attention to wear indicators such as cracked concrete surfaces, pooling water in low-lying areas, and erosion alongside kerbs.

Figure 1

Current Map of Boyes Park, without proposed design changes



Location of Boyes Park, Hamilton, New Zealand. Screenshot from Google Maps (Google, 2024).

To complement our on-the-ground observations, we reviewed journal articles and case studies detailing how targeted additions such as unisex, accessible toilets; strategically placed drinking fountains; and modular seating with built-in recycling bins can both enhance user comfort and promote sustainable park stewardship. Using best practices in universal design and low-impact landscaping, we summarised our findings into a cohesive report organised around short-, medium-, and long-term items. Immediate “quick wins” include upgraded walking and biking tracks and repairing surface cracks, while medium-term proposals suggest additional seating, lighting, rubbish bins, and drinking fountains. Finally, our longer-range goals call for inclusive features like splash pads and accessible car parking and restrooms, as well as refurbishing the historic water fountain to preserve cultural significance and improve functionality. Each recommendation has been carefully thought out to ensure that Boyes Park’s evolution remains inclusive, environmentally responsible, and fully aligned with Hamilton City Council’s broader urban greening strategy.

4. Safety by Design

After conducting site assessments, we collectively identified both actual and perceived safety as a crucial component of Boyes parks redevelopment. A strong sense of safety helps

promote park use and community wellbeing, while perceived risks can deter visitors, specifically older, more vulnerable groups. To address this, we applied Crime Prevention Through Environmental Design (CPTED) principles, focusing on natural surveillance, maintenance, territorial reinforcement, and access control (Thani et al., 2016). These principles informed our design choices, including upgraded lighting, clear sightlines, defined entryways, and community spaces like BBQ areas and splash pad.

To enhance natural surveillance, we proposed ideas such as improved lighting during evening hours, clear sightlines, and low fencing. Lighting not only increases visibility but also reduces fear of darkness, encouraging people to use the park after dark (Subbaiyan & Tadepalli, 2012). More foot traffic during these hours increases natural surveillance by creating a feeling of liveliness rather than isolation. These features act as both deterrents to potential offenders and maintain visibility throughout the park. Natural surveillance works by increasing the perceived risk of being seen, which can outweigh the perceived rewards. A well-lit, open space with physical barriers makes it difficult for offenders to go un-noticed and increases the effort required to engage in anti-social behaviour.

We chose not to recommend installing security cameras at this stage, as they can create a sense of being watched among law-abiding community members, potentially decreasing their sense of safety. Research also suggests that natural surveillance is often just as effective at deterring crime (Seifi et al., 2023).

As part of our safety design, we also proposed using natural elements such as trees, rocks, and hedges as physical barriers to subtly discourage unsafe crossings while enhancing the park's visual and ecological appeal. Hedges, in particular, function as natural fencing, supporting territorial reinforcement while maintaining sightlines for natural surveillance. To ensure they don't compromise visibility, the hedges must be low enough that passers by can still have a clear view of the park.

We also proposed in-ground lighting along main pathways to improve visibility and guide movement through the space, supporting both usability at night and perceived safety. These features collectively contribute to a more secure and welcoming environment in line with CPTED principles.

5. Digital Engagement Strategy

To enhance accessibility and transparency, our team developed an interactive website and a visual site map as key components of our digital engagement strategy. The website was designed to be intuitive, mobile-friendly, and accessible to users of all ages and abilities. It features detailed explanations of proposed park upgrades, an interactive development map, and a feedback form to

capture community input.

The visual map uses clear icons to highlight improvements such as splash pads, lighting, and inclusive facilities. We've also created a QR code intended for distribution throughout the park, linking directly to the site to ensure easy access for the public.

This digital strategy aims to allow for broader community consultation and to provide a platform for the local community to share ideas, submit feedback, make bookings, and stay informed about the project. It supports Hamilton City Council's commitment to inclusive urban development and aligns with Hamilton West Belts Master Plan, which emphasises community feedback as a key component. Ultimately, our goal is to include the public's voice into the park's future planning as the park is being designed for them.

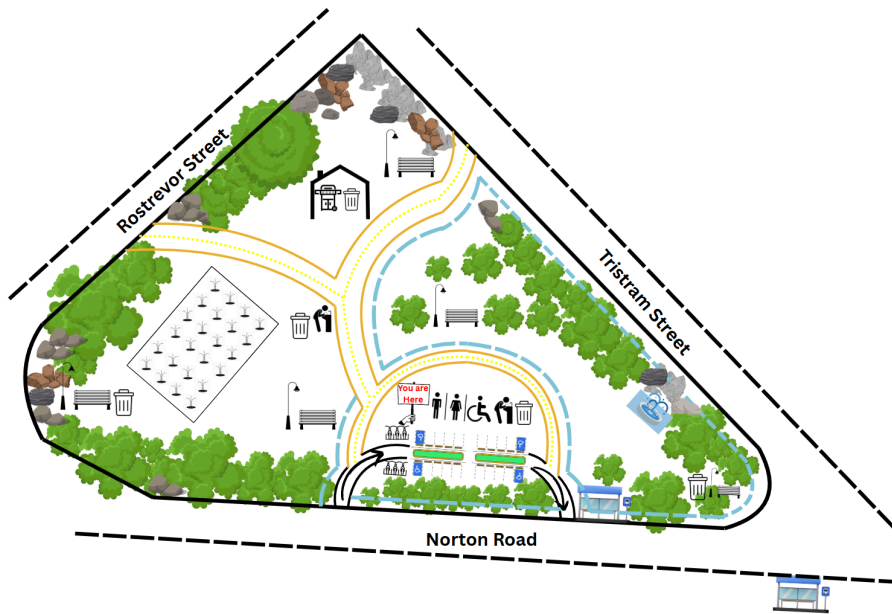
Our website link ([Enhancing/Amenities Team 3](#))

6. Outcomes

The completed project delivers a comprehensive design plan that fully meets the original requirements by transforming Boyes Park into a more accessible, engaging, and sustainable community hub. Key physical outcomes include upgraded walking and biking tracks for safer and more enjoyable active transport; strategically placed additional seating, rubbish bins, and drinking fountains to enhance user comfort and cleanliness; fully accessible restrooms and parking to ensure equitable access for people of all abilities; and vibrant splash pads alongside inclusive play areas that encourage physical activity and social interaction among children of diverse needs. Social spaces have been enriched with dedicated BBQ and gathering zones, while the historic water fountain has been refurbished as a nod to the park's heritage, reinforcing a sense of place and continuity.

Figure 2

Our Proposed Redevelopment Plan For Boyes Park



To support long-term engagement and transparency, we also developed an intuitive digital site map and an interactive website that introduces the project, visualises each phase, and solicits public feedback creating a dynamic feedback loop that keeps the community invested and informed. By addressing observed issues head-on and prioritising community wellbeing, social inclusion, and active lifestyles, this design directly advances several United Nations Sustainable Development Goals: SDG 11 by fostering inclusive, safe, and resilient urban spaces; SDG 3 through the promotion of health and wellbeing via improved recreational facilities; and SDG 10 by reducing inequalities through universally accessible infrastructure.

7. Discussion

This project offers Hamilton City Council a community-informed, sustainability-driven blueprint that transforms Boyes Park from a mundane park into a well-developed park for the community. This comprehensive approach also includes a monitoring and evaluation framework to track usage patterns, maintenance needs, and user satisfaction over time. By embedding universal-access design, well-lit social gathering nodes, and CPTED measures, the council can enhance community trust and engagement residents will see their input reflected in real improvements while improving safety and inclusivity metrics through better lighting, clear sightlines, and accessible pathways that encourage off-peak use by families, seniors, and people with disabilities. It will also establish clear performance indicators such as visitor counts, incident reports, and accessibility audits to ensure ongoing accountability and continuous improvement. To fully leverage these outcomes, the council should integrate our phased recommendations into its capital works schedule and long-term plan budgeting cycle, secure funding (including targeted green-space grants), allocate maintenance resources, and establish an ongoing community co-design working group to refine amenity details. The next steps involve finalising budgets and

approvals for each phase, piloting early-win interventions such as new drinking fountains or pathway repairs to test usage and maintenance workflows. Lessons learnt from these short-term projects can then inform the procurement of materials and contractors for larger-scale works, reducing risks and optimising value for money. Once the park renovation is underway, broadening the vision to include adjacent green corridors or community-led pop-up events that animate the park and build momentum for future place-making initiatives. By incorporating these additional measures, the Council not only revitalises Boyes Park but also builds a replicable model for future urban greening and community-led place-making initiatives.

8. Conclusion

In conclusion, the Boyes Park redevelopment project represents a meaningful step toward enhancing community wellbeing through thoughtful, inclusive, and sustainable public space design. Our team approached this challenge with the aim of transforming a currently underutilized park into a vibrant, accessible and welcoming environment for the community. Grounded in a multidisciplinary framework and informed by site analysis, community needs, and best practice design principles such as Universal Design and Crime Prevention Through Environmental Design, the project provides a roadmap for the revitalization of Boyes Park into a space that reflects the values of equity, safety, and community engagement.

Through a combination of field assessments, background research, and digital innovation, we were able to identify critical gaps in the park's existing infrastructure, such as poor accessibility, inadequate amenities, and low user engagement. In response, our proposal introduces a wide range of improvements, including upgraded pathways, additional seating and lighting, accessible restrooms and car parking, and inclusive recreational features like splash pads. Importantly, we also proposed the restoration of the Centennial Fountain to preserve the historical character of the space while enhancing its utility. These enhancements are designed not only to meet immediate community needs but also to foster long-term wellbeing and cohesion across Hamilton's increasingly diverse population.

A central strength of this project has been the integration of *Safety by Design*, community consultation, and digital engagement tools. Applying key principles from Crime Prevention Through Environmental Design (CPTED), our team focused heavily on improving the overall safety and usability of Boyes Park. Natural surveillance was enhanced through the design of open sightlines and the placement of upgraded lighting along primary walking and cycling routes, including in-ground pathway lighting to increase night-time visibility. We also proposed the strategic use of natural elements such as hedges, trees, and rocks not only to enhance the park's ecological value but to act as soft barriers that discourage unsafe crossings and subtly guide user

movement. These elements contribute to territorial reinforcement and access control while maintaining visual openness and aesthetic appeal.

By combining these safety-focused physical upgrades with clear signage and defined entry and exit points, the park becomes more navigable, secure, and welcoming for all visitors, particularly vulnerable groups such as children, older adults, and people with disabilities. In parallel with these design elements, we developed an interactive website and visual development map to ensure transparency, gather public feedback, and support ongoing dialogue between the community and Hamilton City Council. QR codes displayed throughout the park link directly to the site, allowing users to explore proposed changes, provide input, and stay updated on progress. This approach aligns strongly with the West Town Belt Masterplan's emphasis on community co-design and demonstrates the Council's commitment to creating inclusive, safe, and connected urban spaces.

Moreover, the outcomes of this project align with several of the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly SDG 3 (Good Health and Wellbeing), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities), and SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities). By prioritising accessibility, safety, and environmental stewardship, our design promotes not only physical activity and mental health but also social equity and environmental responsibility.

Looking ahead, we recommend that Hamilton City Council integrate our phased redevelopment plan into its long-term capital works strategy. Early implementation of “quick wins,” such as upgrading lighting and repairing walkways, would allow for immediate community benefit while testing logistics and gathering feedback. Concurrently, establishing a working group to continue community consultation during later implementation phases would ensure that the park remains aligned with public needs over time. In this way, Boyes Park can serve as a model for future green space redevelopment projects in Hamilton and beyond.

Ultimately, this project has demonstrated how collaborative, research-informed planning can transform public infrastructure into a tool for inclusion, resilience, and community pride. It is our hope that the recommendations in this report will support the city in making Boyes Park not just a destination, but a reflection of Hamilton's evolving identity and shared future.

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